

lawstribute

Hello world, this is John Lawless. Well it's on your mind Australia, tell us by darling 13, 13, 32 or fax us if you'd like to. Our fax number is 02 9 0 6 8 8 0 0. If I sound a little breathless this morning it's because I just got in from footy training and I had to do some work on the float for Saturday.

But I've managed to get here and I am here for your listening and dancing pleasure. Right, just as long as you want, see I told you I was out of breath. Call us on 13, 13, 32 or fax us on 02 9 0 6 8 8 0 0. Travel Radio Australia, and it's been a bit of a sad month because we lost an icon of Australian radio.

It's been all over the news across Australia, Mr John Laws and I have on the line with me from Mansfield in Victoria, Craig Willis and funny thing about Craig and I, we both worked at 365 Kent Street with Mr Laws at different stages in our careers. Craig welcome to the programme. Jeff, it's just lovely to hear your voice again old friend.

Yes, it's been a while, we worked together at 3AW for quite some time as well back in the 80s and it was a fantastic experience and you're extremely well known in Melbourne and with all the sport you do for 3AW and Channel 7 and a lot of other people and it's always been a pleasure working with you. We all knew it was coming with Mr Laws but it was still a bit of a shock wasn't it and the whole of Australia it's really moved to the whole country. Well it's amazing the impact that John Laws had, for those of you who don't know he was a Sydney based radio announcer.

They did try to syndicate some of his work into Victoria, it didn't work but he was syndicated over radio stations right throughout New South Wales for many many many years so he was I think described by our Prime Minister as the voice of the nation if you like but what an outstanding broadcaster and very young men and some women in the industry wanted to base our lives very much on what John Laws became. That he sort of invigorated us into learning our craft and wanting to get on radio. Yes and I was reading recently that you worked with him at 365 Kent Street at 2UW and that was an amazing experience.

I was there with him as his panel operator and cart monkey as we used to call it, someone you know making up all the tapes for him and all that sort of thing and all the announcers actually but he was one of the people I work with and that was an amazing place to work at 365 Kent Street back in the 70s. Well I'd left school and I was offered a cadetship with Rep Code which delighted my father who had spent 52 years working with Parramatta Council ending up as the town clerk or Chief Executive Officer as it would be known these days but my mother saw an ad for Dispatch Boys at George Patterson's advertising at 252 George Street in Sydney and she knew I wanted to get into radio. She thought well it wouldn't be a bad way to start so I started on the same day as a boy called Hans Torv, mother of Anna, and at the time brother-in-law of Rupert Murdoch and a guy called Les Gock who was the lead singer of a band called Hush and one of our jobs were various radio stations, 2SM was in Clarence Street, 2UW was in Kent Street and I was dropping a

tape off, came up to me and he said we're looking for an office boy would you be interested? Well I left at the chance I had to do an interview with Mr Jeff Cote and Jeff Cote was the general manager and next thing I was the office boy, Roger later tells me I sort of had the word cadet attached to my name as well and of course Mr Laws as we called him was doing the 9am till midday shift on 2UW at the time and I did these audition tapes put together by a production fellow called Graham Wyatt onto a cassette and on Friday I would drop it into his office and say could you listen to this please Mr Laws and whether he did or not Jeff I don't know but he would then walk past me on Monday or Tuesday throw the cassette at me in a very friendly way and say you could do better than that and that was it so that was my fondest memory of him he was an enigmatic man at times he could be difficult as I think you'd know he just had this warmth about him on air and I think he taught me the first lesson in radio which I tell anyone who wants to get into this industry is learn to talk to your audience not at them.

Yes that was very important I was 17 years old when I was there were all kids really you know looking back on it it was incredible but we thought we were really grown up working with Mr Laws and all the big announcers and everything he really sat me down when I got my first job in Queensland as an announcer because we all dreamed of actually being on the air not just as technical people or tape boys or whatever he found out that I was actually I got a job in a tiny little town called Nambor in Queensland as my first ever on air job at age 17 and he took the time to call me into his office and say look Jeff you've been here for a year I've got to know you and you're a great kid and I really want to give you some advice on being an announcer he started off at a place called 3BO Bendigo which I ended up working there as well I don't know whether you did as well at some point but yeah but that was a fantastic grounding for him and that was his launching of his career but he had some fantastic advice for young broadcasters and he was incredibly supportive as you say well what I didn't know was that he had took one of these cassettes in his car with him he had a farm at a place called Sunny Corner katimba through a place called this go and to It this guy was in an old house on the highway and he called in there and left the cassette with a boy called John Ringwood who was the general manager of the time and I think basically said this kid it could be okay and took off and I never found this out till many years later and then I had a phone call offering me an on-air job with two It list go but John Ringwood the general manager was leaving he had a job with the public service coming up in Canberra but I worked with Craig denier father of Grant and Peter Graham who went on to a great career with two ue and two ws in in Sydney so that was my first station two till four in the afternoon seven till 11 at night so you did two shifts in one day and you turned the transmitter off at 11 o'clock that night when you finished your shift and to me it was seventh heaven we were all getting paid to do what we absolutely loved and looking back we probably would have done it for nothing you know it was don't say that don't say that well it was virtually for nothing anyway because we were it wasn't the greatest of wages back then but no but we we had a brilliant time it was absolutely fantastic and getting back to mr law's as you say he was very very acerbic you know working with him for a long time as I did for over a year he was in his moods and god forbid if you made a mistake I remember I mistimed a carte's tape by two seconds which left him two

seconds short of timing up to the pips and and that was the ultimate sin he he called me in and he said in this very deep voice young man we have to talk and and when I can't do the voice but but when he said that you knew you were in extreme trouble and to him two seconds of dead air was the end of the world he was such a perfectionist and it really taught me at that point I still remember his words 58 years later as if it was yesterday and it really teaches you working with a perfectionist like mr law's how he really ups your game we call it the law's factor you had to be 150 percent and speaking about the other people he was involved with because we've had a few titans of radio and I think we can mention Darren Hinch, Bob Rogers, there was Alan Jones and Stan Zamanek in Sydney and and they were all a bit at war with each other along the way weren't they? Absolutely yeah and then I heard that Leon Miner passed away a couple of days ago in Adelaide but yeah Bob Rogers was nearly 100 I think and he was still doing radio Darren Hinch I'm in contact with on a constant basis he hasn't been well but I'm seeing him in a couple of days time sadly we lost Stan Zamanek some years ago didn't we um but laws had this sort of aura about him I think a lot of it was jealousy Jeff wherever he went in Sydney radio the audience went with him and he was a two-year-old two GB two-year-old every time he went to a radio station he was number one but you as his panel operator would remember at about two and a half three minutes to midday before the two-year-old news he would play Roger Miller exactly let me be a little kinder yeah but he would be able to spin the record come out of what we call delay which was seven seconds in those days and reintroduced the record so it timed out to the midday news perfectly to the I saw him do that often yeah it was just unbelievable piece of studio ship that's the best way I can describe it and of course he had his he's the music that he liked to play a lot of country music because he was a big country music fan but of course he released a number of albums and sang live on television shows with Brian Henderson and Bandstand shows like that going back in the 60s and early 70s oh yes he released a lot of big hits actually he he was he was right into country music as of course a lot of his audience were the truckies in Australia who were huge supporters of John Lawes who used to listen to his program religiously when they were on the road and I remember he also was involved in the blockade there was blockades or convoys as they called them back in the 70s and he actually flew in by helicopter once to be with them for that he was very very involved with that but as you say his audience was incredibly loyal and they would follow him around and he wouldn't suffer falls gladly put it this way and I really respected him for that because love him or hate him and there's a lot of people who don't like Mr Lawes and think he was too acerbic in in their fleeting meetings with him but I could understand where he was coming from because wherever he went he was the spotlight of attention he was like the centre of the universe wherever you went and so I don't blame him occasionally getting a bit snarky with people no very true my last meeting with him was some years ago now that we were dining at Otto's restaurant but down in Wollamadoo he lived at the end of the pier with the princess and he was walking past had a walking stick in those days I went over and I said excuse me Mr Lawes and Craig Willis and he said I said I don't know if you remember he said of course I remember you I've heard you often on this that and the other and I always knew that you had it in you to be a success I presume that he was being genuine or even just being polite put it that way

well he said the same thing to me 20 years after I left to UW he actually I got a chance to talk to him once and he said of course I remember you how could I forget you and he was that kind of person he remembered a lot of people and behind the scenes he was very good to his staff and very good charity he did a lot of charity work which just went unseen by the public and that was really great too but but hey we've run out of time Craig but it's been wonderful catching up with you across the world I'm in Cannes in France and you're in Mansfield in Victoria and it's been wonderful to catch up with you and thank you very much for being on the program and and a little tribute we call him the king of radio and I think he always will be that. And thank you so much and I'll be back in Australia soon and thank you very much Craig for being on Travel Radio Australia. Good on you Geoff, take care my friend.

Take a little more, let me be when I'm weary Just a little bit more cherry, take a little more of others, and a little less of me Let me be a little braver When temptation gets me waver Let me try a little harder To be all that I should be Let me be a little me With the brother that is weaker Let me think more of my neighbour And a little less of me Let me be when I am weary Just a little bit more cherry Let me serve a little better Let me be a little me With the brother that is weaker Thank a little more of others And a little less of me RIP John Laws, it was a pleasure working with you and thank you for launching the careers of so many Australian radio and television personalities.